

COMMUNICATING EFFECTIVELY

Communicating effectively with your patient during a consultation need not take much time or specialised skills. Try to use straightforward language and take into account your patient's culture and belief system.

Integrate these four communication principles into every consultation:

Listen

Listening effectively helps to build an open and trusting relationship with the patient.

Do

- Give all your attention
- Recognise non-verbal behaviour
- Be honest, open and warm
- Avoid distractions e.g. phones

The patient might feel:

- 'I can trust this person'
- 'I feel respected and valued'
- 'I feel hopeful'
- 'I feel heard'

Don't

- Talk too much
- Rush the consultation
- Give personal advice
- Interrupt

The patient might feel:

- 'I am not being listened to'
- 'I feel disempowered'
- 'I am not valued'
- 'I cannot trust this person'

Discuss

Discussing a problem and its solution can help the overwhelmed patient to develop a manageable plan.

Do

- Use open ended questions
- Offer information
- Encourage patient to find solutions
- Respect the patient's right to choose

The patient might feel:

- 'I choose what I want to deal with'
- 'I can help myself'
- 'I feel supported in my choice'
- 'I can cope with my problems'

Don't

- Force your ideas onto the patient
- Be a 'fix-it' specialist
- Let the patient take on too many problems at once

The patient might feel:

- 'I am not respected'
- 'I am unable to make my own decisions'
- 'I am expected to change too fast'

Empathise

Empathy is the ability to imagine and share the patient's situation and feelings.

Do

- Listen for, and identify his/her feelings e.g. 'you sound very upset'
- Allow the patient to express emotion
- Be supportive

The patient might feel:

- 'I can get through this'
- 'I can deal with my situation'
- 'My health worker understands me'
- 'I feel supported'

Don't

- Judge, criticise or blame the patient
- Disagree or argue
- Be uncomfortable with high levels of emotions and burden of the problems

The patient might feel:

- 'I am being judged'
- 'I am too much to deal with'
- 'I can't cope'
- 'My health worker is unfeeling'

Summarise

Summarising what has been discussed helps to check the patient's understanding and to agree on a plan for a solution.

Do

- Get the patient to summarise
- Agree on a plan
- Offer to write a list of his/her options
- Offer a follow-up appointment

The patient might feel:

- 'I can make changes in my life'
- 'I have something to work on'
- 'I feel supported'
- 'I can come back when I need to'

Don't

- Direct the decisions
- Be abrupt
- Force a decision

The patient might feel:

- 'My health worker disapproves of my decisions'
- 'I feel resentful'
- 'I feel misunderstood'